directly. "Our identity, honour, dignity, everything has been snatched away from us. We have even lost our statehood since the last time I addressed a poll rally here in 2014," he declaimed. As the women yelled excitedly, *'Aaya, aaya, sher aaya'* (The lion has come), a throwback to his grandfather Sheikh Abdullah, he added: "We are seeking votes for the assembly even though it does not have the power we need. But NC and its partners will make the assembly powerful again, Inshallah." Omar is targeting both Mehbooba's PDP and the BJP, whom he accuses of "trying to fracture the mandate in the Valley while consolidating it in Jammu".

BJP'S THREE-PRONGED PLAN

In Jammu's Kathua, a district that borders Punjab, Tarun Chugh, BJP's national general secretary in-charge of J&K, is working tirelessly to achieve his party's goal of forming a government and having a chief minister of its own for the first time. The party has been engaged in a rearguard action to strengthen its organisational might here, including getting, like in other states, leaders from other parties—regional and national—to defect to plug its own gaps.

After getting Kathua candidate Rajiv Jasrotia to file his election papers with much fanfare, Chugh, wearing a saffron turban, addresses a well-organised rally on the outskirts of the town. If the NC and PDP are talking of how the Modi government has humiliated them by revoking Article 370 and reducing the state to a UT, Chugh concentrates on evoking nationalistic sentiment, saying how the Modi government has tamed terror in the Valley and ended the ambiguity over Kashmir's status. He then plays the *vikas* (development) card, saying how the BJP has ensured that Jammu is no longer a poor cousin by ramping up rail and road connectivity, providing hospitals (including an AIIMS at Samba), and plans to convert the region into a major industrial and tourist hub. "From a terrorist capital," he declares, "we will make J&K a tourist hub of the world. This election will show that Bharat has won, and Pakistan-backed anti-national forces have lost."

For the Modi government and the BJP, this election is a moment of reckoning. Revoking Article 370 was the biggest move any government had made in J&K since its adoption in 1952. A political victory which can help it form the government on its own will be a final vindication of the action. As Devender Rana, a prominent NC leader from Jammu who joined the BJP in October 2021, puts it, "The BJP's strategy is to form a government without the NC and the PDP, who have still not reconciled with the change in status. The clock cannot go back to a 370 situation where we have two constitutions and two flags. This election will decide whether we vote a government that strengthens the work and progress initiated in the past five years and ensures sustained peace and equitable development."



NOT ONLY IS THIS THE FIRST ELECTION AFTER REVOKING ART. 370, IT IS ALSO THE FIRST IN WHICH SEPARATISTS INSTEAD OF BOYCOTTING ELECTIONS ARE TAKING PART IN THEM

In the past five years, the Modi government and the BJP have been following a three-pronged strategy to achieve these goals. The first saw a crackdown on separatist groups and militants, enforcing law and order and ensuring there were no outbreaks of violence, including stone-pelting. The second included a hard focus on development, especially on building infrastructure, including roads and bridges across the state. The third concentrated on ensuring the BJP's electoral supremacy by building an alternative political leadership in the Valley, away from the *parivarvaad* (dynastic politics) of the Abdullahs, Muftis and the Nehru-Gandhis, who had dominated J&K's politics over 70 years.